

Section B (Discussion)

For this section:

- assessment continues without pause or interruption into this section
- the teacher/examiner will engage the student in a discussion based on the same GTA given on the stimulus card, but the discussion should move away from the main focus and subtopic(s) presented on the stimulus card
- the teacher/examiner should move the discussion on after two minutes to discuss a **different subtopic in the same GTA as the stimulus card**
- the teacher/examiner's role is to try to stimulate students to produce their best performance, taking them to their 'linguistic ceiling' but being careful not to press on with questions of a certain difficulty if it becomes clear that a student cannot cope at that level
- interventions (questions, brief statements, instructions, comments, etc.) should always develop flexibly, building logically on what students have said
- students should not be allowed to produce rehearsed speeches; they should be encouraged to speak independently and spontaneously – students who repeat pre-learned or memorised material should be encouraged to produce more spontaneous discourse
- students have approximately four minutes' discussion time.

Administration and general information about the conduct of the speaking assessment

Preparation time and notes

- The notes made during the preparation time should be a reference only, and students must not read out whole, prepared sentences.
- The preparation time **must** be supervised. It can take place either in the examination room with the teacher/examiner or outside of the room with an invigilator.

- Students are not permitted to write on the stimulus card.
- Students must return their notes and stimulus card to the teacher/examiner at the end of the assessment. Any notes made during the preparation time must be kept securely by the centre until 3 months after results have been released for the assessment.

Oral topic form (OR1)

- Students are allowed to refer to their *Oral topic form (OR1)*, but they are not allowed to write additional notes on it. It will be checked by the teacher/examiner in the examination room.
- Scanned forms will not be accepted for submission to Pearson. Electronically completed forms must be sent as per guidance in the Administrative support guide. The sound files must be submitted electronically to Pearson via a Secure file transfer. Sound files sent to the Examiner on a USB or a CD through the post will not be accepted. Please refer to the *Administrative Support Guide: Conducting oral examinations* for further details.

Assessment window

It is usual for teachers to conduct the speaking assessment with their students during one of two timetabled assessment windows in November/December or in April/May. Information will be available on the Pearson qualifications website: qualifications.pearson.com

Sample assessment materials

Sample student and teacher/examiner cards for the tasks and marking criteria (including guidance of how these criteria are applied) can be found in the *Pearson Edexcel International Advanced Level in French Sample Assessment Materials (SAMs)* documents.

Marking guidance

Marking guidance has been written to accompany the SAMs and is included with the SAMs booklet and in the specification. Please note that this guidance is for the use of the Pearson-appointed external examiner, who will mark the assessments. They are printed for reference only so as to aid understanding of how the criteria are applied.

1.3 Assessment criteria

General guidance on using levels-based mark schemes

There are five levels-based mark grids to be applied to the discussion. The mark grids are:

- quality of language (Accuracy) (AO3)
- quality of language (Range of lexis) (AO3)
- spontaneity and development (AO1)
- understanding (AO2)
- knowledge and understanding (AO1).

Deciding on a marking band

- First of all, the examiner will consider the performance as a whole and then decide which descriptors most closely match the performance and place it in that band. The descriptors for each band indicate the different features that will be seen in the student's performance for that band.

- When assigning a band, the examiner will look at the overall quality of the performance and not focus disproportionately on small and specific parts where the student has not performed quite as well as the rest. If the performance covers different aspects of different bands of the mark scheme, the examiner will use a 'best fit' approach for defining the band.

Using grids with a range of marks within bands

- Then, the examiner will use the variability of the response to help decide the mark within the band that they have selected. For example, if the performance is predominantly band 5-8 with a small amount of band 9-12 material, it would be placed in band 5-8 but be awarded a mark near the top of the band because of the band 9–12 content.
- The examiner will modify the mark based on how securely the trait descriptors are met at that band.

Quality of language (Accuracy) (AO3)

The following mark grid assesses students' ability to apply grammar and syntax accurately, as well as accuracy of pronunciation.

Mark	Quality of language (Accuracy): AO3
0	No rewardable material.
1	• Isolated examples of correct language. • Poor pronunciation and intonation.
2	• Many basic errors, often impeding communication. • Pronunciation and intonation not always comprehensible.
3	• Accuracy variable, basic errors sometimes impede communication. • Pronunciation and intonation comprehensible.
4	• Generally accurate but some errors in more complex language, communication rarely impeded. • Pronunciation and intonation generally good.
5	• Highly accurate but not necessarily error-free. • Pronunciation and intonation authentic.

Quality of language (Range of lexis) (AO3)

The following mark grid assesses students' ability to use a range of lexis and structures.

Mark	Quality of language (Range of lexis): AO3
0	No rewardable material.
1	Very basic lexis; minimal command of structure.
2	Lexis restricted; operates generally in simple sentences.
3	Adequate range of lexis; limited range of structures.

Spontaneity and development (AO1)

This mark grid assesses students' ability to interact with the examiner by giving relevant responses based on what they have heard.

Mark	Spontaneity and development: AO1
0	No rewardable material.
1–4	- Minimal spontaneity. - Cannot develop responses. - Often fails to respond or needs regular prompting. - Very reliant on examiner's language.
5–8	- Some examples of spontaneity. - Limited development of responses. - Some hesitation in more complex areas. - Difficulty with some questions.
9–12	- Many examples of spontaneity. - Some development of responses. - Responds usually without undue hesitation. - Deals adequately in most situations.
13–16	- High incidence of spontaneous, fluent discourse. - Detailed development of responses. - Able to respond readily to all questions. - Develops and sustains discourse well.

Understanding (AO2)

This mark grid assesses students' ability to understand and respond in speech to written language.

Mark	Understanding (stimulus specific): AO2
0	No rewardable material.
1	Limited answers to prescribed questions, demonstrating poor understanding of stimulus text.
2	Satisfactory answers to prescribed questions, demonstrating adequate understanding of stimulus text.
3	Detailed answers to prescribed questions, demonstrating good understanding of stimulus text and its wider implications.
4	Full and detailed answers to prescribed questions, demonstrating excellent understanding of stimulus text and its wider implications.

Knowledge and understanding (AO1)

This grid assesses students' ability to communicate information about and demonstrate knowledge and understanding of a general topic area (GTA). They are also assessed on their ability to present relevant ideas and opinions.

Mark	Knowledge and understanding (General topic area): AO1
0	No rewardable material.
1–2	Hardly any relevant ideas and opinions, demonstrating poor understanding of the general topic area.
3–4	Few relevant ideas and opinions, demonstrating limited knowledge and understanding of the general topic area.
5–6	Some relevant ideas and opinions, demonstrating satisfactory knowledge and understanding of the general topic area.
7–8	Many relevant ideas and opinions, demonstrating good knowledge and understanding of the general topic area.
9–10	Wealth of relevant ideas and opinions, demonstrating excellent knowledge and understanding of the general topic area.